

The Corner Booth

The room is quiet, almost reverent. A soft hum comes from behind the curtain, machines doing whatever they're supposed to do. I don't pay attention anymore. I just sit there, holding her hand—fingers still warm, her pulse soft and slow.

Outside, the sun has begun its slow descent, casting amber streaks across the walls. It reminds me of the coffee shop—the one on 3rd and Willow, with the stained glass windows that caught the evening light just like this.

I smile.

“Do you remember the day we met?” I say gently, my thumb brushing over her wedding ring. “You walked in looking like a lost poem, clutching a coffee with both hands like it was the only thing keeping you warm. There were no seats left... just me, in the corner booth.”

She doesn't answer, but that's okay. She hasn't said much today.

“I offered you a seat, and you took it. You looked at me like I was interrupting something important. I probably was. But then you smiled—and that was

it. That smile. I think I fell in love with you before you even introduced yourself.”

A quiet, almost imperceptible squeeze from her fingers.

I chuckle. “God, we were so awkward. I spilled my espresso. You knocked over the sugar. But we made a plan to meet again. We didn’t know it yet, but we were already making something permanent.”

I let the silence settle for a moment. Her breathing is shallow but steady.

“You remember our first date? That tiny little Italian place by the river? I pretended to know what Chianti was. You pretended not to notice.”

Another smile pulls at my lips, even as my chest aches.

“And the proposal,” I say, closing my eyes. “On your birthday, under the sycamore tree in your parents’ backyard. I was shaking so badly I nearly dropped the ring. You didn’t even let me finish the question—you just kissed me and said yes.”

My voice wavers.

“You always made everything easier.”

Outside, a bird calls once, then flies off. I picture our kids running through the backyard, barefoot and wild, laughter echoing into the trees.

“I wish you could’ve seen Ella’s painting yesterday. She’s got your talent, you know. And Liam? He asked me if love ever ends. I told him... I told him not the real kind.”

Her eyes flutter open for a second. I see it—just for a heartbeat—that spark. That life. That her.

“You were always stronger than me,” I whisper.
“Even now.”

A long pause. I lean in closer, my forehead brushing hers.

“If I had known back then what I know now, I still would have walked into that coffee shop, sat in that corner booth, and fallen in love with you all over again.”

Her fingers twitch once.

And then they go still.

The soft hum behind the curtain continues... but something else stops.

The nurse, who had quietly been standing at a respectful distance, steps closer. She doesn't look at me—just places a hand gently on my shoulder.

“She's gone,” she says, her voice cracking despite her professionalism.

I stare at the hand I'm still holding, trying to feel warmth where there is none. The world feels impossibly quiet.

Three years.

Three years we fought it.

Laughed through it. Cried in secret. Shared every quiet sunrise, every late-night panic, every scan, every bad result, every ounce of hope.

We never told the kids how bad it really was.

She made me promise to keep the memories happy. To hold onto love, not loss.

She didn't want to be remembered for the cancer.

So I won't.

She was my corner booth.

She was my forever.

And she always will be.

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